SUPPORTING DOCUMENTS

These do not themselves confer citizenship but are often accepted as evidence of citizenship

↘ Voter ID
Electoral roll entry

↘ Aadhaar card
Not a citizenship document but often used as supporting proof of residence and identity

PAN card / Driving licence
Not proof on their own, but corroborative

School leaving certificate
Or other government-issued identity cards mentioning place/date of birth

Land or tenancy records
These must show residence before cut-off dates (especially in Assam NRC/Accord contexts)

Ration card: Historically used as supporting proof of residency and family linkage



SPECIAL SITUATIONS

Assam Accord (Citizenship Act, Section 6A): Documents such as inclusion in 1966/1971 electoral rolls, refugee registration or residency records are used to prove citizenship

CAA 2019 beneficiaries: Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Parsis, Christians from Pakistan, Afghanistan, Bangladesh to show proof of religion, country of origin and entry before Dec. 31, 2024

Naturalisation applicants
Must provide proof of residence in India (ration cards, rent agreements, utility bills, tax records)



"A regular exercise, conducted many times in the past to remove ineligible voters, is now being misrepresented as a conspiracy against certain sections of society. That perception is completely unfounded"

— RAM MADHAV
RSS ideologue; Founder, India Foundation



"Documents and divisive politics cannot substitute for fairness and constitutional due process"

— SUSHMITA DEV, *Rajya Sabha MP, TMC*

The Long Pursuit of a Register

Even though it has taken centre stage in the past decade, citizenship verification predates the Modi era. The idea of a nationwide NRC was first mooted in 2003, under the BJP-led NDA government of Atal Bihari Vajpayee. Acting on the recommendations of a Group of Ministers (GoM) set up after the Kargil War, the Citizenship Act, 1955, was amended to mandate identity cards for every citizen, especially in border states. In 2004, the Congress-led UPA went further, inserting Section 14A into the Citizenship Act, making registration of every citizen compulsory, and providing for an NRC.

Linked to the NRC is the National Population Register (NPR), a record not of citizens but of all "usual residents", defined as those living in an area for at least six months or intending to stay another six. Under the 2003 amendment, NPR data serves as the base for preparing the NRC. The NPR collects basic personal and household details—such as name, age, gender, occupation, parents' and spouse's details, education and addresses. Unlike the Census, where individual particulars remain confidential under the Census Act, 1948, NPR data can be used for welfare schemes targeted at individuals or households.

The first countrywide NPR was rolled out in 2010 and updated in 2015 (Assam and Meghalaya were left out). The